Justice B.R. Gavai observed during a Supreme Court hearing.

The apex court had earlier asked the Bengal government to clarify how exactly it had assessed the social and educational backwardness of these communities and whether meaningful consultation with the West Bengal Backward Classes Commission had taken place.

The timing of this fresh OBC identification effort—a year before the 2026 election—has attracted accusations of political opportunism. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) accused the Trinamool Congress (TMC) government of "vote bank politics". "Mamata Banerjee gave OBC reservation to 118 Muslim castes without any survey," Union home minister Amit Shah had said in 2024, in the aftermath of the high court verdict. "Mamata Banerjee wants to rob the reservation of backward classes for her vote bank."

Mamata had dismissed these claims, arguing that the court ruling was politically motivated. "We do not accept the order that scrapped OBC certificates. We will contest at a higher court," she declared at a rally following the verdict.

Recently, Bengal BJP general secretary Jagannath Chatterjee alleged that the fresh survey was intended to "divert resources towards Muslim OBCs" at the expense of Hindu communities.

Politics apart, there is no denying the socio-economic struggles of marginalised communities in West Bengal. Many low-income families, irrespective of religion, have historically faced discrimination and economic deprivation. The process of caste identification must transcend political divides to genuinely uplift those in need, say critics. To do so, it is imperative that data collection is accurate. The state government is being urged to adopt a more scientific approach involving field studies, historical analysis and demographic research to ensure fair outcomes. ■

JAMMU AND KASHMIR

A Tussle Over Transfers

By Kaleem Geelani

Buoyed by the first assembly election in five years in 2024 and the hope of a return to statehood, Omar Abdullah has had a largely frictionless run as chief minister of the Union territory of Jammu and Kashmir. However, a political faceoff with the Centre—held off till now under a veneer of courtesy and cooperation—seemed inevitable. That came to pass last week, when Omar and J&K lieutenant governor Manoj Sinha locked horns over their respective jurisdiction of powers. The immediate trigger was Sinha's transfer of 48 middle-rung officials—16 additional deputy commissioners, 23 sub-divisional magistrates and nine assistant revenue commissioners—all part of the Jammu Kashmir Administrative Service (JKAS), on April 1.

Setting the tone for a direct confrontation between the Union territory's dual power centres, CM Omar organised a meeting of all 42 National Conference (NC) MLAs, along with those of ally Congress, Aam Aadmi Party and Independents on April 4. At the end of it, a veiled warning was served. "Don't push us to the wall. Don't take our friendliness as weakness," said Tanvir Sadiq, MLA and chief spokesperson of the NC.

Though Omar has disagreed with



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